Why Progressive Clarification Matters

Make an idea more precise in deliberate steps—not all at once.

Early product ideas are often a mixture of observations, ambitions, assumptions and feature suggestions. Progressive clarification separates these elements over time, so each decision can build on what is known while keeping uncertainty visible.

Why not define everything at once?

Ideas start incomplete

At the beginning, the user, problem, desired outcome and constraints may all be uncertain.

Early assumptions shape later choices

A premature decision about users or features can quietly determine scope, requirements and architecture.

Clarification reduces avoidable rework

Making uncertainty explicit helps teams ask better questions before investing heavily in a particular solution.

The central idea

Progressive clarification is not endless analysis or a rigid one-way sequence. It is a disciplined way to make decisions at the right level of confidence, revisit them when evidence changes, and gradually connect the idea to a coherent MVP specification.

Remember

Clarify enough to make the next useful decision—not so much that you pretend uncertainty has disappeared.

From rough idea to coherent specification

Each stage makes selected parts of the product more concrete while preserving links to earlier reasoning. The work may loop back when new evidence changes an assumption.

1 · UNDERSTAND THE OPPORTUNITY
Clarify the idea, problem, user context and intended value. Separate the proposed solution from the problem it is meant to address.

2 · STRUCTURE THE PRODUCT LOGIC
Identify desired outcomes and Core Jobs, then connect them to capabilities and a coherent core user journey.

3 · DEFINE AND CHALLENGE SCOPE
Choose what the first coherent experience must include, what can wait, and what is explicitly outside the MVP.

4 · MAKE IT BUILDABLE AND TESTABLE
Specify information, data, requirements, acceptance criteria, learning goals and relevant technical boundaries.

5 · REVIEW AND REVISE
Check consistency and traceability, identify open decisions, then revisit earlier choices when evidence or constraints change.

Important
The 15 MVPCompanion stages provide a structured path, not a claim that all uncertainty can be resolved before development.

What progressive clarification looks like

Use this pattern to decide whether to move forward, ask a question or revisit an earlier decision.

A practical working loop

CLARIFY	What do we currently mean? Make the statement or decision explicit.
CLASSIFY	Is it Evidence (E), Hypothesis (H), Derived (D) or an Open question (O)?
CONNECT	Which user, problem, outcome, Core Job, capability or requirement depends on it?
CHALLENGE	What could make this assumption wrong? What is the smallest useful way to learn?
UPDATE	Record the decision and revise downstream items if the evidence changes.

Good progress

A useful next step is one that reduces an important uncertainty or makes a consequential decision clearer.

Quick self-check: are we clarifying progressively?

Use this checklist when a team is rushing into features, detailed requirements or technical decisions before the product logic is clear.

Self-check

- [ ] Known facts are separated from assumptions and open questions.
- [ ] Problem and proposed solution are not treated as the same thing.
- [ ] The intended user and outcome are becoming more specific as evidence improves.
- [ ] Core Jobs and capabilities connect to the intended outcome.
- [ ] Scope decisions include reasons and explicit exclusions.
- [ ] Requirements and acceptance criteria are developed from clarified product intent.
- [ ] Important decisions can be traced to their rationale and dependencies.
- [ ] New evidence can trigger revision of earlier decisions.

My next clarification step

The most consequential uncertainty is…

The next question or evidence to pursue is…

The downstream decision affected is…

Takeaway

Progressive clarification creates coherence step by step while keeping uncertainty visible.